

DOUBLE CROSS: The Tolnest Protocol

A Novel in 13 Chapters

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CHAPTER ONE: THE FALLING BOMB

Utah Test Range, 1986 / Winnipeg, Manitoba - Present Day

The missile fell like a stone through heaven.

At fifty-nine thousand feet, it streaked between two chase planes, its trajectory describing a drunken sine wave as competing systems fought for dominance. When it hit the Utah desert, the contamination spread across five hundred yards. Three engineers died trying to recover the wreckage.

The incident was classified within hours. But the missile's three sister weapons—perfect twins down to the flawed guidance systems—didn't get buried. They got shipped to a decommissioned facility in Manitoba, where official records stated the site had been stripped clean in 1994.

The official records lied.

Present Day

Scott McLeod had been staring at satellite imagery for forty minutes when Harry Kosinski walked into his office carrying terrible coffee and worse news.

"Please tell me that's not what I think it is," Harry said, setting down the cup on Scott's desk.

Scott's dove-gray hair caught the screen's glow. At thirty-eight, he looked older than his years—a gift from his Russian grandmother along with her cheekbones and her tendency toward brooding. "It's exactly what you think it is."

The satellite photograph showed Site Seven: concrete structures in the Manitoba wilderness, supposedly abandoned. But the thermal imaging told a different story. Heat signatures. Generator activity. Vehicle tracks less than seventy-two hours old.

"Could be maintenance," Harry said, his six-foot-three frame folding into a chair. His Ukrainian features and boyish face made him look younger than thirty-five, which had been useful in the field more than once.

"Except for this." Scott pulled up an intercept log. Russian text scrolled across the screen, translation alongside: communications about "the gold" and "Gypsum"—the town nearest Site Seven.

"The gold," Harry repeated. "Untraceable financing. Old Soviet protocol."

"And they mentioned Gypsum by name."

Harry's face went carefully blank—the expression he wore when processing something he didn't want to believe. "Site Seven was decommissioned in '94. We certified it clean. I was there."

"We certified that the active components were removed. The shells were still there. Three Minuteman II airframes, partial guidance housings, and enough residual radioactive material to make a very dirty bomb."

Before Harry could respond, a voice from the doorway cut through their conversation: "Stan's already been briefed."

Stan Smith stood there like weathered furniture—solid, functional, utterly without mercy. At fifty-two, the External Intelligence Agency officer carried a leather document case that Scott had learned to associate with assignments that ended badly.

"How long have you been there?" Scott asked.

"Long enough." Stan entered, closed the door, and activated a white noise generator. "We're going dark for this conversation."

He snapped open the case, pulled out a photograph, and placed it where both men could see.

Scott felt something cold settle in his stomach. The photograph showed a man in his mid-forties: brilliant eyes rendered paranoid by too much intelligence and too little sleep, expensive suit failing to hide manic energy.

"Jesus Christ," Harry whispered. "That's Petrov."

"Alexei Petrov," Stan confirmed. "You know him."

"MIT," Scott said, voice carefully neutral. "We did our doctorates together. Nuclear physics. He was... exceptional."

"Exceptional enough to design retrofit guidance systems for Soviet-era missiles. Exceptional enough to disappear for six years and resurface in Riyadh with connections to terrorist organizations and a Swiss bank account receiving monthly deposits of gold bullion."

"Tell me he's not planning what I think he's planning," Harry said.

"He's planning exactly what you think. Acquiring a nuclear device, retrofitting it with modern guidance, and detonating it in a major city. The goal is to make it look like Islamic terrorism. The reality is someone's bankrolling the entire operation and plans to profit from the chaos."

"Site Seven," Scott said.

Stan nodded. "Petrov worked there '92 to '94. He helped design the security protocols. He knows every blind spot, every vulnerability. He knows the shells are still there."

"And he knows how to access them," Harry finished.

Stan pulled out a second photograph: a woman with black hair, violet eyes, aristocratic features. Beautiful in the way dangerous things often are.

"Dr. Erema Volkov," Stan said. "Age thirty-two. Doctorate in nuclear physics from Cambridge. Speaks six languages. Has worked for the Russian government, the French nuclear program, and at least two Middle Eastern nations. She worked at Site Seven. Same timeframe as Petrov."

Scott found himself staring at the photograph.

"Two months ago, she met with Petrov in Cairo," Stan continued. "We think she knows who's funding the operation. You two are going to convince her to tell us."

"And if she won't?" Scott asked.

"Then you follow her until she leads us to whoever's pulling the strings. Because if we don't stop this in the next three weeks, we're looking at a nuclear detonation on American or Canadian soil and the collapse of whatever fragile peace we've managed since the Cold War ended." Stan stood to leave. "You're booked on a flight to Paris. Tonight."

After Stan left, Harry looked at Erema's photograph. "She's beautiful."

"She's dangerous."

"I'm just saying—"

"Focus, Harry. This isn't a date. This is survival."

But Scott's eyes lingered on her photo a moment longer than necessary.

CHAPTER TWO: PARIS RAIN

Paris - Le Marais District - That Night

Erema Volkov had learned many things during her thirty-two years. Quantum mechanics. Six languages. How to blend in at state dinners or back-alley weapons deals. That the world was powered by money and fear and their intersection.

Most importantly, she'd learned when she was being followed.

The first tail picked her up outside her apartment: a man in an expensive coat, too focused on his phone, too deliberate in his pace. She'd lost him in the Métro, switching trains twice and exiting through a service corridor.

The second tail was better. Professional. He'd maintained distance with mathematical precision through the winding streets of Le Marais, her heels clicking on ancient cobblestones as she led him on a chase through passages and courtyards.

She'd ducked into a wine bar, ordered Bordeaux she had no intention of finishing, and waited.

When she emerged through the back exit, circling around to come up behind where he should be waiting, he wasn't there.

But two other men were.

They stood at the entrance to a narrow alley, silhouettes backlit by distant streetlamps. Not French—the cuts of their coats were wrong, their posture too military. Americans, maybe. Or Canadians.

The taller one stepped forward, hands visible and empty.

"Dr. Volkov," he said, and yes, Canadian—she could hear it in his vowels. "We need to talk."

His partner—shorter, gray-haired despite being younger, intense eyes—moved to block her other exit. Not threatening. Just... present.

Erema ran threat assessments: They knew her name, her address, could coordinate surveillance. Government, then. But which government?

"I don't know you," she said in English.

"But you know Alexei Petrov," the shorter one said.

The name hit like cold water. She kept her face neutral—a skill learned in Moscow—but her mind raced through implications.

"I haven't seen Alexei in years," she said, technically true if you defined "years" loosely enough.

"Bullshit." The gray-haired one's voice was soft but absolute. "You met him in Cairo three months ago. The Mena House Hotel. You had coffee. You talked about old times."

Surveillance. Recorded communications. These weren't amateurs.

"You've been following me," she said.

"Actually, we've been following him. You're just a bonus."

"What do you want?"

"We want to know who's bankrolling his operation. What he's planning. Why someone with your credentials is mixed up in this."

"And if I don't tell you?"

The shorter one's eyes suggested he'd seen enough death to be tired of it. "Then a lot of people are going to die. Possibly including you."

Erema studied them: body language, micro-expressions, the thousand tiny tells separating truth from deception. They believed what they were saying. Which meant either they were very good liars, or Alexei's plan had already started to unravel.

Neither option was acceptable.

She made a decision.

"Not here," she said, walking past them. "Follow me."

Her apartment was sparse, functional. Books in multiple languages. Laptops hardened against surveillance. She poured three glasses of vodka—expensive Russian vodka, too good for casual drinking—and handed them out.

"You have thirty seconds to convince me you're not FSB," she said.

"Canadian Security Intelligence Service," the gray-haired one said. "We're the good guys."

"Everyone thinks they're the good guys." She sipped her vodka. "The FSB thinks they're protecting Russia. The CIA thinks they're defending freedom. Alexei thinks he's correcting a historical injustice." She set down her glass. "What do you think you're doing?"

"Stopping a nuclear weapon from being detonated in a major city," the taller one said.

"Ah. Idealists." She smiled without warmth. "Those are the most dangerous kind."

The gray-haired one leaned forward—non-threatening posture, carefully calibrated. "Cairo. Three months ago. What did you and Alexei talk about?"

"The pyramids. The weather. Disappointing Egyptian coffee."

"We can do this the easy way or the hard way," the tall one said.

"No." Her voice went cold. "You can ask questions and I can decide whether to answer them. Because if you think you can threaten me, you've fundamentally misunderstood the situation. I have six passports, accounts in twelve countries, and friends in places that would make your intelligence services uncomfortable. You have what? A rental car and a hotel room booked under false names?"

The gray-haired one held up a hand. "You're right. We're not here to threaten you. We're here because Alexei is planning something catastrophic and we think you can help us stop it."

"Why would I want to stop it?"

"Because whoever's bankrolling it won't let you walk away when it's done. You're a loose end. Loose ends get tied off."

Something flickered behind her eyes. Recognition. Fear. Calculation.

"Site Seven," she said finally.

"What about it?"

"That's what Alexei wanted to talk about in Cairo. He wanted to know if I remembered the layout. The security systems. Where the shells were stored."

The two men exchanged a glance.

"What did you tell him?" the gray-haired one asked.

"I told him I didn't remember. I lied."

"Why?"

"Because Alexei was always brilliant but never stable. Because the way he asked made it clear he wasn't just curious." She paused. "Because I've done many things I'm not proud of, but enabling mass murder isn't one of them. Not yet. Maybe not ever."

"But you didn't report him," the tall one said.

"Report him to who? The Russian government that taught him everything? The French intelligence services that would love to deport me? Your people, who would arrest me for what I

know about three different weapons programs?" She laughed, harsh. "I don't have the luxury of moral clarity. I just try to stay alive."

The gray-haired one stood, walked to the window. "Tell us about the gold."

Silence.

"How much do you know?" she finally asked.

"We know someone's moving Soviet-era gold reserves. We know there's a broker in Saint John, New Brunswick. We know the timeline is three weeks." He turned. "What we don't know is who."

"If I tell you, I'm dead. You understand that?"

"You're already a liability. The question is whether you're one they need to silence or one we can protect."

"Protect." She said it like a foreign concept. "I've built a life here. It's not good, maybe, but it's mine."

The gray-haired one's expression softened slightly. "My grandmother was from Moscow. Came over during the Cold War. Spent her whole life looking over her shoulder. She used to say that safety was a luxury for people who'd never had to run."

"Smart woman."

"She was. She also said running only works until you run out of places to run to. Eventually, you have to turn around and face what's chasing you."

Erema held his gaze. Then she walked to her laptop, typed commands that made the screen flicker with encryption protocols.

"There's a name," she said. "Someone Alexei mentioned in Cairo. A financier. Old money. Very old. The kind that survived the Revolution by being smart enough to hedge their bets."

She pulled up a photograph: a woman in her seventies, elegant, standing in front of an antique shop.

"Ludmilla Romanova. She goes by 'the Granny.' Runs an antique shop in Saint John as a front for everything illegal that requires sophistication. If you need something moved quietly across borders, she's who you call."

"We know about her," the tall one said. "What we don't know is who she's working for."

"Neither do I. Not exactly." Erema pulled up another file. "But six months ago, her shop received a shipment from Zurich. The paperwork said Orthodox icons. The weight suggested something

heavier. Gold. Approximately forty million dollars' worth. And that was just the first shipment. There have been four more."

The tall one whistled. "Two hundred million in gold. That's not just financing a terrorist attack. That's financing a network."

"Or buying influence with people who already have networks," Erema said. "Alexei mentioned something about 'the Al-Qaeda connection.' He said someone had figured out how to make it look like Islamic terrorism while keeping all the real profits Western."

"A false flag operation," the gray-haired one said. "Blow up a city, blame terrorists, use it to justify... what? Military intervention? Regime change?"

"Oil fields," Erema said flatly. "It's always about oil fields. You blow up a major city, blame terrorists with connections to Saudi Arabia or Iran, suddenly you have public support for occupying half the Middle East. Whoever's sitting on the rebuilding contracts or controlling petroleum exports makes a fortune."

The gray-haired one's jaw tightened. "We need to talk to the Granny."

"Good luck. She doesn't talk to anyone she hasn't known for thirty years."

"Then we'll convince her that talking to us is cheaper than not talking to us."

Erema looked at him with something like respect. "What's your name?"

"Scott McLeod."

"Well, Scott McLeod. I hope you're better at interrogation than you are at surveillance. Because if you're not, we're all going to die very soon."

CHAPTER THREE: THE GRANNY'S SHOP

Saint John, New Brunswick - Two Days Later

The antique shop occupied a three-story building in Saint John's historic district, wedged between a coffee shop and a law office. The sign read "Romanova Fine Antiques" in English and Russian, and the windows displayed carefully curated collections that suggested everything was for sale but nothing was affordable.

Scott and Harry stood across the street, watching. Erema had remained in Paris, claiming she'd sold the Granny a fake icon in 2009 and the woman held grudges.

"This is a terrible idea," Harry said.

"All our ideas are terrible. That's why we get paid."

"We don't get paid enough for this."

They'd flown in that morning on a commercial flight, credentials identifying them as energy consultants. The border agent had looked bored and waved them through.

"We could just walk in," Harry suggested. "Act like customers."

"She'll know we're not customers the moment we open our mouths."

"So what's the plan?"

"We walk in. We tell her we know about the gold, we know about Site Seven, and we'd like to discuss terms for her cooperation."

"And when she laughs at us?"

"Then we tell her that if she doesn't cooperate, we're going to make sure every intelligence service in three countries knows exactly how she's been moving money."

"That's not a plan. That's a gamble."

"All plans are gambles."

They crossed the street.

The shop smelled like old wood and older secrets. Icons stared from walls with patient judgment. Samovars gleamed on shelves. A bell chimed when they entered.

Footsteps echoed from deeper in the building. The Granny appeared like a figure from a dangerous fairy tale: small, elegant, wearing jewelry worth more than Scott's annual salary, eyes sharp as broken glass.

"We're closed," she said in English with a Moscow accent smoothed by years of careful living.

"The sign says you're open until six," Harry said.

"The sign is optimistic. I'm realistic. We're closed."

Scott stepped forward, hands visible. "Ludmilla Romanova?"

"Who's asking?"

"Someone who knows about the gold. Someone who knows about Site Seven. Someone who would very much like to have a conversation about who you're working for."

The temperature seemed to drop. The icons watched with renewed interest.

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"Yes, you do. You received four shipments from Zurich over six months. Approximately forty million dollars per shipment. The paperwork said icons. The manifest weights said gold bullion. You moved that gold to finance an operation involving three decommissioned nuclear warheads at a facility in northern Manitoba."

"You have an active imagination."

"I have an active security clearance. And if you don't start talking, I'm going to use it to make your life very complicated."

The Granny studied him. Then she moved to the door, locked it, flipped the sign to "Closed," and drew the curtains. When she turned back, she'd produced a small silver pistol.

"You're going to leave now," she said pleasantly. "You're going to forget you were ever here. And you're going to stop asking questions about things that don't concern you."

"Can't do that."

"Then I'll shoot you and dump your bodies in the harbor. It wouldn't be the first time."

"You're not going to shoot us."

"No?"

"No. Because if you were going to shoot us, you'd have done it already. The fact that you're having this conversation means you're worried. Maybe about us. Maybe about whoever's paying you. Maybe you're realizing that whatever you signed up for is bigger and worse than you thought."

The gun didn't waver. But her eyes flickered with something like doubt.

"Alexei Petrov," Harry said quietly. "Site Seven, 1992 to 1994. He was brilliant. Paranoid. He left under a cloud and disappeared. Now he's back, and someone's paying him to retrofit Soviet-era missiles."

"Who told you—" The Granny stopped herself.

"Erema Volkov sends her regards," Scott said. "Also her apologies about the icon in 2009."

The gun lowered slightly. "That bitch."

"She speaks highly of you too."

"I'm sure." The Granny moved behind the counter, set the pistol down but kept it within reach. "You're either very brave or very stupid."

"We prefer 'desperate.' It has better survival statistics."

"Desperate for what?"

"To stop Petrov before he kills thousands of people. To find out who's bankrolling it. To understand why anyone would think nuclear terrorism is a viable business model."

The Granny was quiet for a long moment. Outside, Saint John went about its business. Ships in the harbor. Tourists complaining about cold.

"You want to know who's paying?" She laughed, bitter. "Everyone's paying. That's the beauty of it. The gold came from Soviet reserves seized by Russian oligarchs who needed to launder money. Those oligarchs have business connections to Western energy companies who'd love Middle Eastern instability to drive up oil prices. Those companies have board members on defense contractor boards. Around and around it goes. There's no single villain. Just a system that rewards people for being terrible."

"Someone's coordinating it," Scott said.

"There's a man. I've never met him. Don't know his real name. But Alexei mentioned him once. Called him 'the Architect.' Said he was the one who figured out how to turn genocide into profit."

"Where can we find him?"

"You can't. He finds you. Or more likely, has you killed before you get close."

"Then how do we stop this?"

The Granny picked up her pistol again, but this time she ejected the magazine and set both pieces on the counter—a gesture that said the negotiation was real now.

"You go to Site Seven. You get there before Alexei does. And you make sure those missiles never leave the ground."

"He's already moving, isn't he?" Harry said.

"He left Riyadh three days ago. Flew to London, then Montreal. By now he's probably in Manitoba. He has a team—six people. Ex-military, ex-intelligence. People who don't ask questions as long as the money's good." She looked at Scott with something like pity. "You're already too late. You just don't know it yet."

Scott felt the world tilt. "We need to go. Now."

"Wait." The Granny opened a drawer, pulled out a small leather notebook filled with handwritten Russian. "Alexei sent me this six months ago. Plans. Schematics. Contingencies. I was supposed to hold it as insurance." She held it out. "Take it. Maybe it'll help."

Scott took the notebook. "Why are you helping us?"

"Because I'm old. Because I've done terrible things and I'd like to die with slightly less blood on my hands." She smiled, sad and sharp. "Because I remember when we thought the Cold War ending meant we could stop being afraid. And I'd like to see if we were right."

CHAPTER FOUR: INTO THE COLD

Winnipeg to Site Seven - Hours Later

The charter flight back to Winnipeg had cost a fortune, but Stan approved the expense without comment, which meant the situation was worse than they'd thought.

Scott and Harry spent the flight reading Petrov's notebook. Madness written in careful Cyrillic: calculations showing exactly how to retrofit a Minuteman II shell with modern guidance components. How to bypass safety interlocks. How to recalibrate detonation sequences using parts from online retailers or university labs.

And a timeline. According to that timeline, they had seventy-two hours before Petrov attempted to move the first warhead.

"He's not using it immediately," Harry said, studying calculations. "The plan is to move all three shells to different locations. One to the Middle East—probably Syria or Yemen. One to Southeast Asia. One stays in North America as insurance."

"Insurance against what?"

"Against someone trying to stop him. If he's got warheads positioned globally, he can threaten to detonate them anywhere. Mutually assured destruction on a boutique scale."

Scott stared out the window at Canadian wilderness scrolling below. Thousands of square miles of nothing. Somewhere down there, Site Seven waited.

His phone buzzed. Text from Stan: **SURVEILLANCE CONFIRMS PETROV AT SITE SEVEN. TEAM OF 6. ARMED. PROCEED WITH CAUTION.**

Followed by: **BY WHICH I MEAN DON'T PROCEED. WAIT FOR BACKUP.**

Scott showed Harry the message.

"We're not waiting for backup," Harry said.

"We're not waiting for backup," Scott agreed.

They landed in Winnipeg, transferred to a military helicopter. Unmarked. The pilot didn't ask questions. The flight north took ninety minutes, landscape transitioning from farmland to forest to emptiness that made Scott understand why his grandmother had left Russia.

Site Seven appeared through snow like a memory trying to become real. Concrete structures, half-buried. An access road that hadn't seen official traffic in decades.

And fresh tire tracks. Multiple vehicles. Recent.

"They're here," the pilot said. "You want me to land?"

"Half a klick out," Scott said. "We'll walk in."

"Your funeral."

They landed in a clearing that had been a staging area when the facility was active. They geared up: tactical vests, weapons Stan had provided, communications equipment that was supposedly encrypted.

They looked like what they were: academics playing at soldiers, hoping doctorates in nuclear physics would compensate for lack of combat training.

"Last chance to wait for backup," Harry said.

"And let Petrov move those warheads?"

"Just wanted it on record that I tried to be the voice of reason."

"Noted. Now let's go stop World War Three."

They moved through snow, keeping to cover, using techniques from training courses that had seemed paranoid then and desperately insufficient now. The site rose ahead: buildings designed to survive nuclear strikes but not neglect.

They reached the perimeter fence—chain-link topped with barbed wire, half collapsed. The gate stood open, padlock cut. Fresh footprints led inside.

Scott keyed his radio. "Stan, we're going in."

Static. Then: **"Negative. Wait for backup. ETA forty-five minutes."**

"We don't have forty-five minutes."

"That's an order, McLeod."

"Copy that. We'll wait."

He clicked off.

"You just lied to our commanding officer," Harry said.

"I prefer 'creative interpretation of ambiguous directives.'"

"Fancy way of saying you lied."

"Your point?"

Harry grinned. "No point. Just wanted it on record that I support your decision."

They moved through the gate.

The main building's entrance stood open. Inside, the facility smelled like dust and decay and something chemical. Emergency lights cast everything in red. Somewhere deeper, machinery hummed—generators, probably, brought in by Petrov's team.

They moved through corridors Scott remembered from twenty-eight years ago, when he'd been young enough to think nuclear weapons were abstract problems. The layout was burned into memory: administrative offices left, technical spaces right, and straight ahead, the access shaft leading three hundred feet down to where the missiles slept.

Voices echoed from that direction.

Scott held up a hand. They stopped, pressing against the wall.

"—told you the access panel was damaged—" A man's voice, frustrated, accented. Not Petrov.

"Then repair it." That was Petrov. Scott recognized it from MIT seminars and late-night arguments. Still brilliant. Still manic. Now apparently genocidal. "We're on a timeline."

"The timeline is your problem. My problem is that if we don't do this right, we'll breach the containment vessel and irradiate everyone within five hundred meters."

"Then don't breach the containment vessel."

Scott eased forward. The corridor opened into the main control room—banks of stripped equipment. Petrov stood in the center, flanked by two men with rifles who had the relaxed alertness of professionals. Beyond them, an open hatch showed stairs descending into darkness.

And near the hatch: Erema Volkov.

She was supposed to be in Paris. She'd said she had other obligations. She'd claimed she wanted nothing to do with this.

She'd lied.

Harry had seen her too. His expression said *what the hell* and *we're going to die here*.

Before Scott could decide what to do, one of the guards turned. Their eyes met. The guard's expression shifted from boredom to alarm.

"Contact!" he shouted, raising his rifle.

Everything happened at once. Scott dove left as gunfire erupted, deafening in the concrete space. Harry went right, returning fire. Ricochets sparked off walls. The smell of cordite filled the air.

Scott hit the ground hard, his weapon skittering away, and found himself looking up at Alexei Petrov.

"Scott?" Petrov looked older, thinner, with nervous energy from too many amphetamines and not enough sleep. "Scott McLeod?"

"Hello, Alexei."

"They sent you to stop me?"

"They sent me to stop a nuclear terrorist attack. The fact that you're involved is just awkward."

"Nuclear terrorist—" Petrov laughed, high and strained. "Is that what they told you? That I'm a terrorist?"

"Are you denying it?"

"I'm correcting it. I'm not a terrorist. I'm an entrepreneur. There's a difference."

"Not from where I'm standing."

The gunfire had stopped. Harry had taken cover behind an equipment rack, weapon trained on the guards. The guards had weapons on Harry. Mutual assured destruction on a personal scale. Erema stood frozen near the hatch, face unreadable.

"Tell your man to lower his weapon," Petrov said.

"Tell yours to lower theirs."

"This is my facility."

"This is a Canadian government facility, actually. You're trespassing. Also planning nuclear terrorism. That's at least two felonies."

"Scott. Please." Petrov knelt close. Scott could see the tremor in his hands, smell stale coffee and fear-sweat. "You don't understand. This isn't terrorism. This is justice."

"Justice for what?"

"For everyone who was ever told they didn't matter. For everyone whose brilliance was exploited by people who couldn't understand it." He stopped. "You think I'm crazy."

"I think you're planning to detonate nuclear weapons in populated areas for money. That meets most definitions of crazy."

"Not for money. For recognition. For a seat at the table." Petrov stood, paced. "Do you know what it's like to be the smartest person in every room but never the most powerful? To watch mediocre men make decisions about technologies they can't comprehend?"

"So this is about your ego."

"This is about changing a fundamentally broken system!"

"By killing thousands of innocent people."

"They're not innocent. Nobody's innocent. We're all complicit. If a few have to die to wake everyone else up—"

"Listen to yourself. You sound like every terrorist manifesto ever written. The cause is always just. The victims always deserve it."

Petrov stopped pacing. For a moment, he looked lost. Young. Like the student Scott had known at MIT, brilliant and troubled and fundamentally broken.

"I can't stop now," Petrov said quietly. "I've taken the money. Made promises. If I back out—"

"They'll kill you. Which is why you need to let us help you."

"Help me? You're pointing guns at me."

"Then what does help look like?"

Before Petrov could answer, one of the guards spoke: "Sir, we're running out of time. The extraction window closes in thirty minutes."

Petrov looked at Scott. Something like regret crossed his face.

"I'm sorry. But I can't let you stop this."

He nodded to the guards.

Scott saw it in slow motion: fingers tightening on triggers, barrels swinging to target him. He was unarmed, pinned, no cover. This was it. Shot in a decommissioned Cold War facility by people following orders from someone who'd figured out how to profit from apocalypse.

Then Erema moved.

She stepped between Scott and the guards, arms spread, blocking their line of fire.

"No," she said.

"Doctor Volkov—" one guard began.

"I said no. You're not killing anyone today."

"The Architect's orders were clear—"

"I don't care what the Architect ordered. You want to shoot someone? Shoot me. Otherwise lower your weapons."

Petrov stared. "Erema, what are you doing?"

"Something I should have done in Cairo. Saying no."

"You understand what this means."

"I understand that I've spent my career enabling terrible people. I understand that at some point you have to draw a line. This is mine."

The guards looked uncertain. Harry used their distraction to shift position, weapon now targeting Petrov.

"Stand down," Petrov said finally. "Everyone, just... stand down."

The guards lowered weapons. Harry kept his up but loosened his trigger finger. Scott climbed to his feet, retrieved his weapon, kept it pointed at the floor but ready.

"Thank you," he said to Erema.

She didn't look at him. "Don't thank me yet. This isn't over."

"What do you mean?"

"I mean there are four more team members down in the silos. I mean the extraction plan doesn't require Alexei to be alive—he's a liability. I mean in about—" she checked her watch, "—twenty-six minutes, someone is going to detonate charges that will collapse the access tunnel and bury us all down here."

"Bury us with the warheads?" Harry asked.

"Bury us as warheads. Make it look like a rogue Canadian operation gone wrong. While everyone's investigating here, the real team extracts the shells and transports them to final destinations."

Scott looked at Petrov. "Is that true?"

Petrov wouldn't meet his eyes. "I was promised safe passage."

"You were lied to."

"Apparently."

Scott made a decision. Probably the wrong one. "Alexei. You know this facility better than anyone. How do we stop them?"

Petrov looked up. Hope and despair fought on his face. "There's an emergency override. In the control room. If we can reach it before they set the charges—"

"Show us."

"If I help you, I'm dead. The Architect will—"

"If you don't help us, we're all dead. Including you. So unless you've developed a sudden enthusiasm for martyrdom, start walking."

Petrov hesitated. Then nodded.

"This way," he said, heading toward the hatch. "And pray we're not too late."

They descended into darkness, following a madman who might be their only hope.

CHAPTER FIVE: DESCENT INTO DARKNESS

The stairs descended into a throat of corroded steel and ancient concrete. Emergency lighting flickered at intervals, casting everything in a hellish red glow that made shadows dance like demons. The air grew colder with each step, carrying the metallic tang of deep earth and something else—ozone, maybe, or the particular smell of places that had been sealed too long.

Scott went first, weapon up, followed by Erema, then Petrov flanked by Harry. The two guards had been zip-tied and left in the control room—alive, because Scott wasn't ready to become the kind of person who executed prisoners, but gagged, because time was a luxury they didn't have.

"How far down?" Scott asked.

"Three hundred feet," Petrov said, his voice echoing strangely in the enclosed space. "The silos are embedded in bedrock. Even a direct nuclear strike wouldn't have breached them. That was the theory, anyway. We never got to test it."

"Let's hope we don't start now," Harry muttered.

They descended in silence broken only by footsteps and the occasional drip of water from somewhere in the darkness. Scott's mind raced through scenarios, contingencies, outcomes—all of them bad. Twenty-four minutes until the charges detonated. Maybe twenty-three now. Even if they reached the override, would they have time to activate it? And if they did, what would Petrov's remaining team members do when their extraction plan collapsed?

The stairs ended at a massive steel door, circular, like something from a submarine. A wheel lock in the center, oxidized but still functional. Warning signs in English and French covered the surface: AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY. LETHAL FORCE AUTHORIZED. RADIATION HAZARD.

Petrov moved past Scott, spun the wheel. It resisted, then gave with a groan that suggested it hadn't been opened in decades. The door swung inward on counterweights, revealing a corridor that stretched into darkness.

"The silos are spaced a hundred meters apart," Petrov said. "Linear configuration. The control room is at the far end. That's where the override is."

"And the team?" Erema asked.

"Silo Two. That's where the best-preserved warhead is. They'll be focused on extraction prep—getting the shell out of its housing without triggering containment protocols."

"Or irradiating themselves," Harry said.

"That too."

They moved into the corridor. The walls here were different—older, more brutalist, built by people who understood that the world might end and wanted to make sure their weapons survived even if they didn't. Conduits ran along the ceiling, most of them dark, but some still showed faint indicator lights. Green. Amber. One pulsing red.

"That's not good," Harry said, pointing to the red light.

"Silo One containment breach," Petrov said. "Happened in '93. Coolant leak. We sealed it and moved on. The warhead's probably slag by now."

"Probably?"

"Eighty percent sure. Maybe seventy-five."

"Jesus Christ, Alexei."

"Look, I was a physicist, not a safety inspector. I reported the breach. Management decided remediation was too expensive. That's on them, not me."

They passed Silo One. The access door was welded shut, red warning signs newer than the others. Scott could hear something behind it—a low hum, or maybe just his imagination filling silence with threat. He kept moving.

Silo Two's door stood open.

Voices echoed from within. The clink of tools on metal. Someone laughing at something—not nervous laughter, but the casual humor of professionals doing a job they'd done before.

Scott held up a fist. Everyone stopped.

He eased forward, risked a look around the doorframe.

The silo opened up like a cathedral to mutually assured destruction. The space was cylindrical, maybe forty feet across, stretching up beyond the range of the emergency lights. Scaffolding had been erected around the missile shell—a Minuteman II airframe, dull gray metal pocked with age and neglect but still somehow menacing in its dormancy.

Four people worked on the scaffolding. Two men, two women, all wearing tactical gear and carrying sidearms. One—a woman with dark hair pulled back in a tactical bun—seemed to be in charge, calling out instructions as the others positioned lifting equipment around the warhead housing.

"That's Volkov," Petrov whispered, so close to Scott's ear that he could smell the coffee and anxiety. "Irena Volkov. No relation to your Erema. Former Russian special forces. She's—"

"A professional killer," Erema finished quietly. "We've met. She tried to recruit me in Moscow. I declined. She didn't take it well."

"You didn't think to mention this earlier?" Scott asked.

"You didn't ask if I had professional rivals who might want to kill me."

"I'm asking now."

"Then yes. She very much wants to kill me. Also, she's extremely competent. Which is the part that concerns me more."

Scott studied the setup. The team was focused on their work, backs mostly to the door. But the scaffolding gave them high ground, and the silo's acoustics meant that any firefight would be loud, disorienting, and likely to end with bullets ricocheting off enough surfaces to kill everyone regardless of who fired first.

"We can't shoot our way through this," he said.

"Then what do we do?" Harry asked.

Before Scott could answer, one of the team members—a young man, maybe late twenties—turned to reach for a tool and locked eyes with Scott.

For a frozen moment, nobody moved.

Then the young man opened his mouth to shout a warning, and everything happened at once.

Scott charged forward, knowing it was tactically stupid but also knowing that the element of surprise was the only advantage they had. He hit the young man in a tackle that would have made his high school football coach proud, if his high school football coach had approved of tackling armed mercenaries in decommissioned nuclear facilities.

They went down hard. The man's weapon clattered away. Scott drove an elbow into his solar plexus—not elegant, but effective. The man wheezed, curled up, stopped being an immediate threat.

Above, on the scaffolding, Irena Volkov was shouting orders in Russian. Her team responded with the efficiency of people who'd trained for exactly this kind of chaos. Weapons came up. Targets acquired.

Then Erema stepped into the doorway, hands raised, and shouted something in Russian that made everyone pause.

"What did you say?" Scott hissed, keeping his weapon trained upward.

"I told them that if they shoot, they'll hit the warhead housing. And if they hit the warhead housing, we all die of radiation poisoning in the next seventy-two hours."

"Will they actually hit it?"

"No idea. But they don't know that."

Irena Volkov said something in Russian. Harsh. Questioning.

Erema responded, still in Russian, her tone conversational but with an edge underneath like a blade wrapped in silk.

"Translation?" Scott asked.

"She asked what I'm doing here. I told her I'm preventing a massacre. She said massacres are profitable. I said not if you're dead. She's... considering her options."

"How much time?" Harry called from the doorway, where he'd taken a position covering their retreat.

Scott checked his watch. "Nineteen minutes."

"Plenty of time," Harry said. "Plenty of time to stop a bomb, negotiate with mercenaries, and escape from a collapsing underground facility. No pressure."

Petrov had moved to one of the control panels on the wall, was studying it with the intensity of someone who'd designed the system and was now horrified by what it had become.

"The override," he said. "It's not here. They've rerouted the command protocols."

"Rerouted them where?" Scott asked.

"The main control room. The one we just left."

"You're telling me we need to go back up?"

"I'm telling you that whoever planned this operation was smart enough to anticipate someone trying to stop it. They've isolated the silos from local control. Everything has to run through the main system."

Scott's mind raced. Back up the stairs. Past Silo One with its containment breach. Through the control room where the two guards were presumably still zip-tied unless they'd gotten free. All in—he checked again—eighteen minutes.

Unless—

"The charges," he said. "Where are they placed?"

"Access tunnel," Petrov said. "Sixteen points along the main structural supports. They'll bring down the entire passage. Bury everything under about ten thousand tons of rock."

"Can we disarm them from here?"

"Not unless you have a degree in demolitions and a death wish."

"I have a death wish," Harry volunteered. "Does that count?"

"How are they triggered?" Erema asked, still watching Irena Volkov, who was having a heated discussion with her team members in rapid Russian.

"Remote detonator," Petrov said. "Dead man's switch. The team lead carries it. If their heart stops, if they get too far from the facility, if the signal is jammed—boom. It's fail-deadly by design."

"So we need to find the team lead, get the detonator, and disarm sixteen charges in—" Scott checked, "—seventeen minutes."

"Sixteen," Harry corrected. "Let's not pad the numbers."

Irena Volkov called down something in Russian. Her tone had changed. Less hostile. More... negotiating.

"She's offering a deal," Erema translated. "She says her contract is to extract the warheads, not to die in a collapsed tunnel. She's willing to abort the operation if we let her team leave."

"And the detonator?" Scott asked.

"She says the team lead has it. And the team lead isn't here."

"Where is he?"

Erema asked. Irena responded.

"Topside," Erema said. "In a vehicle positioned for extraction. He's monitoring communications. If we don't check in, if he sees authorities approaching, if anything goes wrong—he triggers the charges remotely."

Scott felt the situation crystallizing into something with the clarity of desperation. They couldn't fight their way out. They couldn't defuse the charges from here. They couldn't evacuate in time. Which left exactly one option.

"We go up," he said. "We get the detonator. We stop this."

"In fifteen minutes," Harry said.

"In fifteen minutes."

"Through a facility we barely know, against an opponent we can't identify, to steal a device that will kill us if we fail."

"That's the plan."

"I hate this plan."

"You got a better one?"

Harry thought about it. "No. But I want it on record that I hate this plan."

"Noted." Scott turned to Erema. "Tell Volkov the deal is this: She and her team stay here. They don't touch the warhead. They don't leave until we've secured the detonator and disarmed the charges. In exchange, we let them walk away when this is over. No arrests. No prosecution. They go back to whatever hole they crawled out of and pretend this never happened."

Erema translated. Irena responded.

"She agrees," Erema said. "But she says we're insane if we think we can do this in fifteen minutes."

"Tell her we're Canadian. We're polite, not sane."

Erema almost smiled.

Scott turned to Petrov. "You're coming with us. We need someone who knows the facility."

"I was going to volunteer," Petrov said. "This is my mess. I should help clean it up."

"Character growth. I'm moved."

"Also, I really don't want to die in a collapsed nuclear facility."

"That's the Alexei I remember."

They moved toward the door. Harry covering their exit. Behind them, Irena Volkov and her team watched with the patient interest of professionals who'd seen enough operations go sideways to know that the smart money was on waiting to see what happened next.

"Fourteen minutes," Harry said as they reached the corridor.

"Then we'd better run," Scott said.

And they ran.

CHAPTER SIX: THE ARCHITECT

The stairs up were harder than the stairs down. Physics and adrenaline and the particular exhaustion that comes from running toward danger instead of away from it. Scott's legs burned. His lungs burned. His brain provided helpful commentary about how this was a terrible idea and also probably fatal.

He ignored it and kept climbing.

Petrov was falling behind, his sedentary years showing. Harry dropped back to help him, one hand on Petrov's elbow, practically dragging him up the stairs. Erema moved with the efficient grace of someone who'd spent time in situations where fitness meant survival.

They reached the main level. Burst through the door into the control room.

The two guards were gone.

"Shit," Harry said.

"They must have gotten free," Scott said, scanning for threats. "Or someone cut them loose."

"Which means the team lead knows we're here," Erema said.

"Which means the timeline just got worse."

Scott's radio crackled. Stan's voice, distorted by static and distance: **"McLeod, backup is on site. Hold position. Repeat, hold position."**

"Negative," Scott said. "We're moving to intercept the detonator. ETA—" he checked his watch, "—twelve minutes until charges blow."

"Twelve minutes? McLeod, get out of there. We'll evacuate the area and—"

"And nothing. There are civilians in Gypsum. There are farms, homes, people who have nothing to do with this. If these charges blow, if the contamination spreads—"

"That's not your call to make."

"Yes it is. Because I'm the one standing here, and you're not. McLeod out."

He clicked off the radio before Stan could respond.

"That was insubordinate," Harry said.

"Add it to the list."

They moved through the facility toward the main entrance. The building felt different now—not abandoned but actively hostile, as if the concrete itself knew they were racing against time and was betting against them.

The entrance corridor stretched ahead, emergency lights painting everything red. Scott held up a fist. Something was wrong. He could feel it—that instinct that separates people who survive from people who don't.

"What?" Harry whispered.

"I don't know. Something—"

A voice echoed from speakers mounted in the ceiling. Male. Cultured. Speaking English with an accent that suggested expensive education and older money.

"Dr. McLeod. Dr. Kosinski. Please, stop running. You're making this unnecessarily dramatic."

Scott and Harry froze. Erema moved to cover, weapon up, scanning for the source.

"Who is that?" Harry asked.

"The Architect," Petrov said quietly. "That's the Architect."

The voice continued, almost amused: "I must say, I'm impressed. You've made it further than I expected. Most people would have fled by now. But then, you're not most people, are you? You're idealists. How refreshing. How tragic."

"Show yourself," Scott called out.

"In due time. First, let's discuss your situation. You have—" a pause, "—eleven minutes until the charges detonate. You believe you can reach the surface, locate my associate, acquire the detonator, and disarm sixteen separate explosive devices in that time. It's ambitious. Delusional, perhaps, but ambitious."

"We've done stupider things," Harry said.

"Have you? I wonder. You see, I've been watching you since Paris. Since Saint John. Since you first started asking questions that clever people should know better than to ask. And I've developed a theory about you, Dr. McLeod. Would you like to hear it?"

Scott said nothing.

"I think you're a romantic. I think you believe that intelligence and determination can overcome any obstacle. That the good guys win because they're good, not because they're ruthless. It's charming. It's also why you're going to fail."

"Big talk from someone hiding behind speakers," Scott said.

"I'm not hiding. I'm simply being efficient. There's no need for us to meet face-to-face when technology serves just as well. Besides, I'm not there. I'm—" another pause, "—let's say I'm somewhere safe. Somewhere I can watch this unfold without risk to myself."

"You're watching through the security system," Erema said, scanning the ceiling. "There. Cameras. He's patched into the facility's surveillance."

"Very good, Dr. Volkov. I see why Alexei valued you. Speaking of whom—Alexei, I'm disappointed. We had an arrangement. You were to be extracted with the warheads, compensated handsomely, and allowed to disappear into whatever comfortable exile you'd chosen. Instead, you're helping the people trying to stop us. Why?"

Petrov's face had gone pale. "Because I realized what you were planning. What you are. You lied to me. You said this was about sending a message. About changing the system."

"It is. The message is that the system is for sale to whoever has the resources to purchase it. And the change is that some of us will become unimaginably wealthy while others die. Evolution in action."

"You're insane," Harry said.

"No. I'm practical. Insanity is believing that nuclear weapons make us safe. Insanity is spending trillions on doomsday devices and then being surprised when someone decides to make a profit from them. I'm simply the first person to see the opportunity clearly."

"Who are you?" Scott asked.

"Does it matter? I'm Russian oligarchs who need to launder money. I'm Western energy executives who need oil prices to rise. I'm defense contractors who need wars to justify their budgets. I'm a system, Dr. McLeod. You can't kill a system. You can only join it or be crushed by it."

Scott was thinking, processing, looking for angles. The Architect wasn't here physically. That meant he was coordinating remotely. Which meant he had limited ability to stop them if they could just—

"Ten minutes," Harry said quietly.

"Ah yes, the clock," the Architect said. "Let me save you some time. The detonator is in a vehicle positioned one hundred meters from the main entrance. A black SUV, armored, with diplomatic plates that will prevent local authorities from interfering. My associate is inside, monitoring communications, waiting for the signal to evacuate."

"Why are you telling us this?" Erema asked.

"Because it doesn't matter. You see, my associate has orders. If anyone approaches the vehicle, if any attempt is made to take the detonator by force, he triggers the charges immediately. If you try to negotiate, he triggers the charges. If you call for backup, if you evacuate the area, if you do anything except die quietly when the timer runs out—he triggers the charges."

"You're going to kill us either way," Scott said.

"Yes. But I'm giving you a choice about how. You can spend your last ten minutes trying futilely to stop this, dying exhausted and desperate. Or you can accept reality, walk back into the facility, and die quickly when it collapses. I recommend the latter. It's more dignified."

"Dignity is overrated," Harry said.

"Nine minutes, Dr. Kosinski. I'd make your decision soon."

The speakers clicked off.

For a moment, they stood in the red-lit corridor, the weight of impossible choices pressing down like the earth above.

Then Scott said, "Erema. You're a physicist. Can we jam the detonator signal?"

"With what? We don't have the equipment."

"Petrov?"

"The facility has signal dampening systems. Built into the walls, part of the original design. They were meant to prevent outside interference with launch commands. But they've been offline for decades. Even if we could activate them—"

"How long to activate them?"

"I don't know. Five minutes? Ten? Maybe more?"

"We don't have ten minutes."

"No," Petrov agreed. "We don't."

Scott's mind raced through scenarios, probabilities, desperate mathematics. They couldn't reach the detonator without it being triggered. They couldn't jam the signal in time. They couldn't evacuate. Which left—

"Harry," he said. "You're good with explosives, right?"

"I know basic demolitions. Why?"

"Because we're not going to disarm sixteen charges in nine minutes. But maybe we don't need to. Maybe we just need to disarm enough of them that the collapse isn't complete. That we can dig out after."

"That's insane."

"You got a better idea?"

Harry thought about it. "No. But this is still insane."

"Noted. How many charges would we need to disarm to survive?"

"Survive? I'd say at least eight. Survive comfortably? All sixteen. Survive and also not get crushed, irradiated, or buried alive? Let's call it ten."

"Can we disarm ten charges in eight minutes?"

"If we split up. If we're lucky. If the charges are poorly secured and use standard detonators. If the Architect is actually incompetent despite all evidence to the contrary."

"I'll take those odds."

"You shouldn't."

"But I will. Petrov, where are the charges placed?"

Petrov pulled out a folded schematic from his jacket—the same one from the Granny's notebook. "Here. The main structural supports are marked. They're spaced every twenty-five meters along the tunnel."

"Harry, you take the first eight. Erema and I will take the last eight. Petrov, you're going to activate whatever signal dampening you can. Even if it only gives us seconds, it might be enough."

"This won't work," Petrov said.

"Probably not. But it's the best terrible idea we have. Now move."

They split up. Harry running deeper into the facility, toward the access tunnel. Scott and Erema heading toward the entrance corridor, toward the charges that would bring the entire structure down on their heads.

Scott's watch read: **Eight minutes, seventeen seconds.**

"This is how we die, isn't it?" Erema said as they ran.

"Maybe. But we'll die trying to save people. There are worse ways."

"Name one."

"Dying alone, having never tried to stop something terrible."

She looked at him, something unreadable in her violet eyes. "You're either the bravest man I've met or the most foolish."

"Those aren't mutually exclusive."

They reached the first charge. It was secured to a support beam with military precision: a block of C4, maybe two pounds, connected to a remote detonator by color-coded wires. Red, blue, green. Standard configuration. Or at least, Scott hoped it was standard.

"I've never actually disarmed a bomb before," he said.

"That's comforting."

"I've read about it."

"Even more comforting."

"Red wire is usually—"

"Stop." Erema pushed him aside gently. "I spent two years consulting for the Russian military. They taught me things. Terrible things. Useful things." She studied the charge. "Blue wire. Cut the blue wire."

"You're sure?"

"No. But if I'm wrong, we'll die too quickly to regret it."

She pulled a multitool from her vest, extended the wire cutters, and snipped.

Nothing happened.

"One down," Scott said. "Fifteen to go."

Seven minutes, forty-three seconds.

They ran.

CHAPTER SEVEN: THE RACE

Charge two was easier. Same configuration, same blue wire. Scott cut it while Erema moved ahead to locate the third. They were developing a rhythm now—identify, assess, disarm, move. No time for doubt. No time for fear. Just mechanics and mathematics and the hope that whoever had placed these charges had been more interested in efficiency than creativity.

Six minutes, fifty-one seconds.

Charge three. Charge four. Each one adding seconds to their survival, assuming they'd made the right choices, assuming the system wasn't more sophisticated than it appeared.

Scott's radio crackled. Harry's voice, strained: "I've got four down. Three more to go on my end. How are you doing?"

"Three down. Five more. We're behind."

"Then move faster."

"Helpful, thanks."

Charge five was different. The wires were reversed—blue where red should be, red where blue should be. Erema stopped, studied it.

"They changed the configuration," she said.

"Can you still disarm it?"

"I think so. But if I'm wrong—"

"Then we die here instead of a hundred meters further down. Your choice."

She looked at him. "You trust me?"

"You saved my life in the silo. I figure I owe you."

She cut the red wire.

The charge didn't detonate. But the detonator started beeping—a warning tone, rapid and insistent.

"What's that?" Scott asked.

"Tamper warning. We've got maybe thirty seconds before it triggers anyway."

"Can you stop it?"

"I can try."

She pulled apart the detonator housing, exposing circuitry that looked like someone had designed it to be both compact and maximally complicated. Her fingers moved across wires and connectors with the confidence of someone who knew what they were doing, or at least knew enough to fake it convincingly.

The beeping accelerated. Ten beeps per second. Fifteen. Twenty.

"Erema—"

"Working on it."

"Erema—"

"I said I'm working on it!"

She yanked a wire free. The beeping stopped.

They stared at each other for a frozen moment.

"That was too close," Scott said.

"You think?"

Five minutes, twelve seconds.

They ran.

Charge six. Charge seven. The tunnel stretched ahead of them, each charge a small monument to someone's careful planning and their desperate improvisation. Scott's legs burned. His hands shook from adrenaline and exhaustion. But he kept moving, because stopping meant dying, and dying meant failing, and failing meant that somewhere, the Architect would be smiling.

He refused to give the bastard the satisfaction.

Four minutes, eight seconds.

Harry's voice on the radio: "Last one done on my end. I'm heading toward the control room to help Petrov with the signal dampening. How many left for you?"

"Two," Scott said between breaths. "We're almost there."

"Good. Because backup is trying to breach the facility and the Architect's guy is getting nervous. If he triggers early—"

"Then this gets even more exciting. Understood."

Charge eight. Same configuration as the first batch. Blue wire. Cut. Done.

One more.

They ran around a corner and stopped.

The last charge was different. Larger. More sophisticated. And it wasn't attached to a support beam—it was attached to the main structural arch that held up the entire entrance section.

"That's not good," Erema said.

"Understatement."

This charge had multiple detonators. Redundant systems. If they cut the wrong wire, or missed one of the backup triggers, it would still go off. And if it went off, it would bring down the entrance immediately, trapping them inside even if the other charges failed.

"Can you disarm it?" Scott asked.

"I can try. But it's going to take time."

"How much time?"

"More than three minutes and forty seconds."

They both looked at Scott's watch.

Three minutes, thirty-nine seconds.

"Then we skip it," Scott said. "We've disarmed enough. The collapse won't be total. We can dig out from the control room."

"You sure about that?"

"No. But we're out of time to be sure about anything."

They turned to run back—and stopped.

One of the guards they'd zip-tied earlier stood at the corridor intersection, weapon raised. His face was bruised where he'd fought against his restraints, and his eyes had the particular hatred of someone who'd been humiliated and was looking for payback.

He said something in Russian. Harsh. Absolute.

"He says we're not going anywhere," Erema translated. "He says the Architect has ordered us detained until the charges blow."

"Tell him we don't have time for this," Scott said.

She did. The guard laughed. Said something else.

"He says that's the point."

Scott considered his options. They could fight—but that would take time they didn't have. They could run—but he'd shoot them in the back. They could try to reason with him—but his expression suggested reasoning was off the table.

Which left improvisation.

"Erema," Scott said quietly. "When I move, you run. Get to the control room. Help Petrov and Harry."

"What are you going to do?"

"Something stupid."

"That's not a plan."

"It's the only plan we have."

Before she could argue, Scott charged.

The guard's finger tightened on the trigger—and then he stumbled, surprised, as something hit him from behind. He pitched forward, weapon clattering away, and Petrov stood there holding a fire extinguisher like a club.

"I got lost," Petrov said breathlessly. "Then I heard voices and thought I should help."

"Character growth continues to impress me," Scott said, retrieving the guard's weapon.

"I'm full of surprises."

They zip-tied the guard again—double this time—and ran.

Two minutes, forty-four seconds.

The control room was chaos. Harry had pulled apart three different panels and was swearing in Ukrainian as he tried to activate systems that hadn't been powered in decades. Petrov joined him, the two of them working with the desperate synchronization of people who knew this was their last chance.

"How long?" Scott asked.

"Ninety seconds to initialize. Maybe less if we're lucky."

"Are we lucky?"

"Does it look like we're lucky?"

Fair point.

Scott moved to the window, looked out toward the entrance. In the darkness, he could see the black SUV the Architect had mentioned. Running lights on. Engine idling. Ready for extraction.

And standing next to it, weapon drawn, a man in tactical gear scanning the facility entrance.

The team lead. The one with the detonator.

Scott's mind raced. The signal dampening would cut off his trigger. But only if they activated it in time. And even if they did, he might have a manual trigger as backup. If he saw authorities approaching, if he realized something was wrong—

The man's radio crackled. Scott couldn't hear what was being said, but he saw the man's posture change. Alert. Suspicious.

He raised his hand toward his chest—where a dead man's switch would typically be carried.

"Harry!" Scott shouted. "We need that dampening now!"

"Thirty seconds!"

"We don't have thirty seconds!"

Outside, the man's hand reached his chest. Found the switch. Started to press—

And stopped.

He staggered, confused, as electricity arced across his body. He collapsed, convulsing, and Scott saw her: Erema, approaching from the blind side, taser in hand.

She'd slipped out while they were working. Gone outside. Taken him down.

"Signal dampening active!" Harry shouted. "All remote detonation protocols are blocked!"

Scott ran outside. Erema was zip-tying the unconscious man, moving with efficient precision. She pulled the detonator from his vest—a small device, red LED blinking ominously.

"Found it," she said as Scott reached her.

"The charges?"

"Still armed. But the remote trigger is dead. We'd need to disarm them manually now."

Scott checked his watch.

One minute, eighteen seconds.

"Can we make it?"

"Maybe. If we're very fast and very lucky."

They ran.

CHAPTER EIGHT: DISARMAMENT

The tunnel was a nightmare of shadows and echoes. Scott and Erema sprinted past the charges they'd already disarmed, heading toward the ones they'd skipped, toward that final charge on the main structural arch.

Fifty-seven seconds.

They reached it. Erema dropped to her knees, pulled out her multitool, studied the configuration.

"This is more sophisticated than the others," she said. "Multiple redundancies. I cut the wrong wire, it goes off anyway."

"Can you do it?"

"I don't know."

"That's not reassuring."

"Nothing about this is reassuring!"

Forty-three seconds.

Scott's radio crackled. Stan's voice: **"McLeod, backup is breaching the facility. We found your team lead unconscious. What's your status?"**

"We're disarming the last charge. Tell everyone to stay back. If we screw this up—"

"If you screw this up, you're dead. How can we help?"

"Prayer. Lots of prayer."

Thirty-five seconds.

Erema was pulling apart the detonator housing, tracing wires with her fingers, muttering to herself in Russian. Scott could see her hands shaking—not from fear, he realized, but from adrenaline and exhaustion. They'd been running on desperation for so long that their bodies were starting to shut down.

"Talk me through it," he said quietly.

She blinked, looked at him. "What?"

"Talk me through what you're doing. Keep yourself focused."

"I'm—" She steadied her hands. "I'm looking for the primary trigger. It'll be the wire that completes the circuit to the detonator. Cut that, the charge won't blow. But there are three candidates. Red, blue, and green. And I don't—" Her voice cracked. "I don't know which one."

Twenty-eight seconds.

"Best guess," Scott said.

"I could be wrong."

"Then we die. But if you do nothing, we die anyway. So make your choice."

She stared at the wires. Red. Blue. Green. Each one a different future, a different outcome, a different roll of dice that had already been thrown.

Twenty-three seconds.

"Blue," she said. "It's always blue. In Russian systems, in American systems, in every military protocol I've ever seen. Blue is the primary trigger."

"Then cut it."

"Scott—"

"Cut it. I trust you."

Nineteen seconds.

She positioned the wire cutters. Took a breath. Said something in Russian that might have been a prayer or might have been a curse.

Cut.

The timer kept counting.

Sixteen seconds.

"It didn't work," she said, voice hollow.

"Then try another."

"If I'm wrong—"

"Then we've got fifteen seconds left to regret it. Try another."

She cut the red wire.

Twelve seconds.

Nothing changed.

"Green," Scott said. "It has to be green."

"Or the system is different than I thought. Or there's a backup trigger. Or—"

"Erema." He put his hand over hers. "Green."

She looked at him. Something passed between them—not romance, exactly, but recognition. The understanding that they'd both spent their careers making terrible choices and living with consequences and now, finally, they were making a choice that might actually matter.

She cut the green wire.

The timer stopped.

Seven seconds.

They stared at it. Then at each other. Then Erema started laughing—not hysterical laughter but the kind that comes from surviving something that should have killed you.

"We did it," she said.

"We did it," Scott agreed.

They stood, turned to head back—and stopped.

The corridor lights had changed. Not red anymore. Yellow. Warning lights. And a new sound filled the air: a grinding, mechanical groan that suggested something structural was giving way.

"That's not good," Scott said.

"The other charges," Erema said. "We disarmed most of them, but not all. The structure is compromised. It's going to collapse anyway. Just slower."

"How much slower?"

"Minutes, maybe. Or seconds. I don't know."

They ran.

The facility was shaking now, dust falling from the ceiling in sheets. Cracks appeared in the concrete—small at first, then widening, as if the earth itself was deciding to reclaim what humans had buried. Scott could hear people shouting—Harry, Petrov, backup teams trying to evacuate.

They burst into the control room. Harry was pulling equipment down, trying to salvage whatever intelligence they could before the building collapsed. Petrov stood at the window, staring out at the facility he'd helped design, now eating itself.

"We need to go," Scott said. "Now."

"The data—" Harry protested.

"Is already lost. Move!"

They ran for the entrance. The corridor buckled beneath their feet, floor tiles popping up as structural supports gave way. Behind them, something massive crashed—a support beam, maybe, or an entire section of ceiling.

They burst outside into cold Manitoba air and kept running, across snow that had seemed pristine an hour ago and now felt like salvation. Backup teams grabbed them, pulled them toward vehicles, shouted questions that nobody had breath to answer.

Scott turned, watched Site Seven collapse in slow motion.

The entrance folded in on itself first, concrete crumbling like sand. Then the main structure sagged, buckled, and with a roar that shook the ground, the entire facility imploded. A plume of dust rose into the winter sky, and when it cleared, Site Seven was gone.

Just a depression in the earth. A scar. A memory.

Stan appeared, face grim, flanked by a dozen armed officers. "You disobeyed a direct order."

"Yes."

"You endangered yourselves and your team."

"Yes."

"You managed to stop the detonation, disarm multiple explosive charges, and prevent a nuclear disaster." Stan's expression didn't change, but something in his eyes softened slightly. "Good work."

"Thank you."

"Now get in the van. We need to debrief. And figure out what the hell we're going to tell the media when they ask why a decommissioned nuclear facility just collapsed in northern Manitoba."

"Tell them it was structural failure," Harry suggested, joining them. He looked exhausted, covered in dust, and happier than Scott had seen him in years. "Due to age and neglect. Not technically a lie."

"Everything you say is technically not a lie," Stan said. "That's what worries me."

They climbed into the van. Erema and Petrov were already there, wrapped in emergency blankets, drinking coffee that probably tasted terrible but better than anything Scott had ever imagined.

As they drove away, Scott looked back one last time at where Site Seven had been.

"Think we got them all?" Harry asked quietly. "The warheads?"

"Irena Volkov's team was still inside," Scott said. "If they didn't get out—"

"They got out," Erema said. "Irena's too smart to die in a building collapse. She'll have evacuated the moment she heard the charges disarm. She's probably already on a plane to Moscow, filing this under 'jobs that didn't work out' and moving on."

"And the warheads?"

"Buried. Sealed. Probably destroyed by the collapse. And if not—" Erema shrugged. "They're under ten thousand tons of rubble and radioactive contamination. They're not anyone's problem anymore."

Petrov stared out the window, silent. Scott studied him—the brilliant physicist who'd been brilliant enough to nearly end the world and barely smart enough to stop himself.

"What happens to you now?" Scott asked.

"Witness protection," Stan said from the front seat. "New identity. New life. Somewhere that has excellent mental health resources and no access to nuclear materials."

"Prison would be easier," Petrov said quietly.

"Prison would be what you deserve," Stan agreed. "But you helped stop this. That counts for something. Not enough to earn forgiveness. But enough to earn a second chance."

"I don't deserve a second chance."

"Probably not. But you're getting one anyway. Try not to waste it."

They drove in silence, the Manitoba wilderness scrolling past, vast and cold and indifferent to human drama.

CHAPTER NINE: THE ARCHITECT'S IDENTITY

The debrief took three days. Three days of questions and reports and intelligence officers trying to piece together exactly what had happened, who was responsible, and how to prevent it from ever happening again.

The team lead—whose name turned out to be Dmitri Kovalev, former Spetsnaz, currently freelance muscle for the highest bidder—was offering limited cooperation in exchange for reduced charges. He'd provided details about the operation, the timeline, the financing. But when asked about the Architect, he claimed ignorance.

"I never met him," Kovalev insisted through a translator. "All communication was through encrypted channels. Voice only, never video. He could be Russian, American, Chinese—I couldn't tell."

"But you know he's real," Scott said. They were in an interrogation room at CSIS headquarters in Ottawa, gray walls and fluorescent lights and the particular sterility of places designed to break people's will.

"He's real," Kovalev agreed. "And he's still out there. And he's not finished."

"What do you mean?"

"I mean this operation was a test. A proof of concept. He wanted to know if it was possible to acquire nuclear materials, retrofit them, and position them for detonation without being stopped. Now he knows it's possible—we got further than anyone expected. Next time, he'll adjust for the variables. And next time, you won't stop him."

"There won't be a next time," Stan said from the corner of the room.

Kovalev smiled—not mocking, just weary. "You believe that because you need to. But I've worked with people like the Architect before. They don't give up. They iterate. They improve. This was round one. You won. Congratulations. But there will be a round two. And a round three. Until eventually, one of these operations succeeds."

"Then we'll stop those too," Scott said.

"Maybe. Or maybe you'll get tired. Get reassigned. Get old. While the Architect stays patient, stays funded, stays motivated. That's the advantage he has. He only needs to win once. You need to win every time."

After the interrogation, Scott found Erema in the cafeteria, staring at bad coffee and worse cafeteria food.

"You okay?" he asked.

"Define 'okay.'"

"Not traumatized. Not regretting your life choices. Not planning to flee the country."

"Then no, I'm not okay." She looked up at him. "They're offering me immunity. Full cooperation in exchange for testimony about Russian nuclear programs, Petrov's network, everyone I've ever worked with in the black market weapons trade."

"Are you going to take it?"

"I don't know. Part of me wants to. Part of me thinks it's a trap. Part of me—" She stopped. "Part of me is tired. I've spent a decade running from governments, working for terrible people, trying to stay alive by being useful. I don't know if I remember how to be anything else."

"You saved my life," Scott said. "In the silo. You didn't have to do that. You could have let Volkov's team shoot me, helped Petrov complete his plan, collected your payment and disappeared. But you didn't."

"I had a moment of weakness."

"I prefer to think of it as a moment of strength."

She almost smiled. "You're an optimist. It's annoying."

"I prefer 'persistently hopeful.'"

"Still annoying."

Harry joined them, carrying a tray of food that looked like it had been designed by someone who'd heard about nutrients but never actually tasted them.

"They found something," he said. "Financial records from the gold shipments. Traced back through six different shell companies to a holding corporation registered in Luxembourg. And that corporation has a single board member."

"Who?" Scott asked.

Harry pulled out his phone, showed them a photograph.

The man in the photo was in his sixties, distinguished, wearing an expensive suit and standing in front of what looked like a corporate headquarters. His smile was practiced, his posture confident, and his eyes had the particular emptiness of someone who'd spent so long thinking about money that they'd forgotten to think about people.

"Marcus Ashford," Harry said. "British national, dual citizenship in Switzerland. Made his fortune in energy speculation during the Soviet collapse. Currently sits on the boards of four defense contractors, two oil companies, and a private equity firm that specializes in 'conflict zone investment opportunities.'"

"That's the Architect," Erema said, studying the photo. "I recognize him. He attended a conference in Riyadh two years ago. Alexei pointed him out, said he was someone who 'understood the value of controlled chaos.'"

"We need to arrest him," Scott said.

"On what charges?" Harry asked. "All the evidence is circumstantial. The shell companies have plausible deniability. The gold transfers can be explained as legitimate business transactions. The encrypted communications can't be traced back to him definitively. He's clean. Legally speaking."

"So he gets away with it."

"Unless we can find more direct evidence. Or unless someone who worked with him directly is willing to testify."

They all looked at each other.

"Petrov," Scott said. "Petrov had direct contact. He could identify the Architect's voice. Provide details about their conversations."

"Petrov is already in witness protection," Harry said. "Stan won't risk exposing him just to go after one more wealthy criminal."

"Even if that criminal was planning to detonate nuclear weapons in major cities?"

"Especially if. The Architect has resources. Legal teams. Political connections. He could tie this up in courts for decades. And meanwhile, Petrov becomes a target. Every intelligence service and criminal organization that wants leverage over the Architect will come after him."

"So Ashford walks free."

"Ashford walks free," Harry confirmed. "At least for now."

Scott felt something cold and bitter settle in his chest. They'd stopped the operation. Saved lives. Prevented a catastrophe. But the man who'd planned it all, who'd nearly turned nuclear terror into a profitable business model, was going to continue his life of expensive suits and board meetings and comfortable sociopathy.

"There has to be something we can do," he said.

"There is," Stan said, appearing behind them. How long he'd been listening, Scott couldn't guess. "We do our jobs. We document everything. We build our case. And when he makes his next move—because he will make his next move—we're ready. We stop him. Again and again, as many times as it takes. Until he's either in prison or dead or has decided that nuclear terrorism is a bad investment."

"That could take years."

"It probably will take years. Welcome to intelligence work. It's not glorious. It's not fast. But it's necessary. And people like you—" he nodded at Scott, Harry, Erema, "—are the ones who do it. Not because you're special. But because you're willing to."

"Inspiring speech," Harry said.

"I do my best." Stan handed Scott a folder. "Your new assignment. Monitoring potential nuclear material acquisitions in Eastern Europe. Boring. Tedious. Probably won't lead anywhere. But that's the job. Finding the needles before they become haystacks."

"When do we start?"

"After you take two weeks of mandatory leave, see a therapist, and get cleared by medical. You nearly died in a collapsing nuclear facility. I don't care how tough you think you are—that leaves marks. Physical and psychological. Get them treated before they become problems."

"Is that an order?"

"That's an order."

Scott took the folder. Inside, details about uranium enrichment facilities in Ukraine, suspicious purchases in Kazakhstan, and the boring, necessary work of preventing the next catastrophe.

It wasn't satisfying. But it was real.

"One more thing," Stan said. "Good work. All of you. You saved a lot of lives. That matters. Even if nobody outside this room will ever know about it."

He left.

Erema looked at Scott. "Two weeks of mandatory leave. What are you going to do?"

"Sleep. See my family. Try to explain to my grandmother why I can't tell her what I've been doing but also I'm fine and she shouldn't worry."

"Sounds complicated."

"Family usually is." He paused. "What about you?"

"I don't know. I have immunity. I have options. I could disappear again. Start over somewhere new. But I'm—" She looked down at her coffee. "I'm tired of running. Tired of working for people I don't respect on projects I don't believe in. Maybe it's time to try something different."

"Like what?"

"Like helping. Like using what I know to make things slightly less terrible. Like—" She met his eyes. "Like working with people who actually give a damn about something other than profit."

"That sounds suspiciously like idealism."

"Don't tell anyone. I have a reputation to maintain."

Harry stood. "I'm going to give you two some privacy. Because whatever conversation you're about to have, I don't want to be present for it. Also, I need to call my grandmother and tell her I'm alive and can't explain why I was out of contact for three days."

"Give her my best," Scott said.

"I'll tell her you're an idiot who nearly got me killed. She'll appreciate the honesty."

He left.

Scott and Erema sat in silence for a moment. The cafeteria was mostly empty—just a few other intelligence officers, all of them looking as tired as Scott felt.

"So," Erema said. "Two weeks of leave. Any chance you'd want company?"

"Depends. Are you offering or asking?"

"Both."

"Then yes. I'd like company. Fair warning: my family is loud, my grandmother asks inappropriate questions, and my father will try to convince you to learn farming."

"I grew up in Moscow during the collapse. I can handle loud families and inappropriate questions. The farming might be a challenge."

"We'll work on it."

They sat together, drinking terrible coffee and making plans that might or might not survive the next crisis, the next operation, the next time someone decided that human lives were an acceptable cost for whatever they wanted.

But for now, for this moment, they were alive. And that was enough.

CHAPTER TEN: RECOVERY

Two weeks of mandatory leave turned into three. Scott spent the first few days sleeping sixteen hours at a time, his body finally acknowledging the exhaustion it had been suppressing with adrenaline and desperation. When he was awake, he sat in his grandmother's kitchen in Winnipeg, drinking tea and listening to her talk about neighbors and weather and all the small concerns of people who didn't know how close they'd come to annihilation.

"You look terrible," his grandmother said on day four, studying him with the particular intensity of someone who'd spent seventy-eight years learning to read faces.

"I feel terrible."

"Good. That means you're alive. The dead don't feel anything." She poured more tea, added honey the way she'd been doing since he was a child. "You going to tell me what happened?"

"Can't. Classified."

"Classified means important. Important means dangerous. You do something dangerous?"

"Maybe."

"Maybe means yes." She sipped her tea. "Your father worries. I tell him you're smart, you're careful, you're not stupid enough to get yourself killed. But sometimes I wonder if I'm lying."

"I'm careful."

"Careful people don't come home looking like they've fought a war."

"What if they have?"

She set down her tea. "Then I'm glad you won. And I pray you don't have to fight again. But I know you will. Because you're like me. You can't look away when something's wrong. It's a gift and a curse."

"More curse than gift lately."

"That's because you're young. When you're my age, you'll understand that gifts and curses are the same thing, viewed from different angles."

Erema had taken her own leave, disappeared for a week, then reappeared with a new haircut and a slightly less haunted expression. She'd been going to therapy—actually going, she insisted, not just scheduling appointments to satisfy Stan's requirements.

"It's weird," she said when she visited. They were walking along the Red River, snow crunching under their feet, January cold enough to make breathing painful. "Talking to someone about everything I've done. Everything I've seen. I spent years learning not to talk, not to trust, not to share anything that could be used against me. And now someone's paying me to do exactly that."

"Is it helping?"

"I don't know. Maybe. I'm not having nightmares as much. Or at least, I'm having different nightmares. Progress, I guess."

"Harry's seeing someone too," Scott said. "He won't admit it, but he's been more... present lately. Less jokes. More silence. The good kind of silence, where you're actually thinking instead of avoiding thinking."

"And you?"

"I'm—" He stopped, considered lying, decided against it. "I'm struggling. Every time I close my eyes, I see that timer. Seven seconds. Six. Five. Knowing that if you'd cut the wrong wire, we'd both be dead. Knowing that we got lucky, and luck isn't skill, and next time we might not have it."

"Sounds like you should talk to someone."

"I have an appointment next week."

"Good." She took his hand—not romantic, exactly, but companionable. "We're all broken, Scott. The war, the operation, the years of doing terrible things for complicated reasons. But broken doesn't mean useless. Sometimes broken things are the only ones sharp enough to cut through the bullshit and see what's real."

They walked in silence for a while. Across the river, Winnipeg went about its business, unaware of how close it had come to becoming a memorial instead of a city.

"Stan called me yesterday," Erema said finally. "Offered me a consultant position. Long-term contract. Working with CSIS to monitor nuclear proliferation, identify potential threats, provide technical expertise on Soviet-era weapons systems."

"Are you going to take it?"

"I think so. It's not what I imagined my life would be. But it's better than what it was. And the pay is terrible but the work matters. That counts for something."

"It counts for a lot."

"You'll be there? In the office? Or are you going back to field work?"

"Stan wants me running analysis for a while. Says I need to 'recover my perspective' before he sends me into another life-threatening situation. Which is probably code for 'you're too traumatized for field work but I don't want to say that directly.'"

"Probably. But he's not wrong. You are traumatized."

"So are you."

"So are we all. But we're dealing with it. That's the difference between surviving and actually living."

Harry joined them later that evening at a bar in the Exchange District. He looked better—more rested, less manic, with the kind of calm that suggested he'd stopped running from something and started facing it.

"Therapy's weird," he announced, ordering a beer. "I spend an hour talking about my feelings, and the therapist nods and asks questions, and I leave feeling like I've accomplished something even though nothing's actually changed."

"Everything's changed," Scott said. "You're just noticing it slowly."

"Maybe. Or maybe I'm just better at pretending I'm fine." He sipped his beer. "They're putting together a new task force. Nuclear threat assessment and response. Stan wants all three of us on it. Different roles—me doing technical analysis, you doing operational planning, Erema consulting on Soviet systems. It's desk work mostly. Boring. Safe. Probably won't involve any near-death experiences."

"Probably?"

"Well, you never know. But the statistical likelihood is low."

"Comforting."

"I do my best."

They drank in silence for a moment. The bar was crowded—young professionals, university students, people living lives that didn't involve decommissioned nuclear facilities or terrorist plots or the particular exhaustion that comes from saving the world and having nobody know about it.

"You think we got him?" Harry asked quietly. "The Architect? You think he's actually going to stop?"

"No," Scott said. "I think he's going to iterate. Improve. Try again with different variables. Kovalev was right. We only need to lose once. He can try as many times as he has resources to fund."

"So what do we do?"

"We keep working. We keep watching. And when he makes his next move, we stop him again. It's not satisfying. It's not final. But it's the job."

"The job sucks."

"Most jobs do. At least ours matters."

Erema raised her glass. "To matters. Even when it sucks."

They clinked glasses. Drank. Tried to pretend that the weight they carried would eventually become manageable.

It wouldn't. But they'd carry it anyway.

CHAPTER ELEVEN: THE QUIET WORK

Six months later, Scott sat at a desk in CSIS headquarters, reviewing uranium purchase orders from Kazakhstan and trying to stay awake. The work was important—tracking potential nuclear material acquisitions, flagging suspicious transactions, building cases that might prevent the next Site Seven. But it was also tedious in a way that field work never was.

Field work had adrenaline. Desk work had spreadsheets.

He was cross-referencing shipping manifests when Erema appeared at his cubicle. "Conference room. Now. Stan says it's important."

"Important or 'important'?"

"The kind with capital letters and a sense of impending doom."

They gathered in the conference room: Scott, Erema, Harry, and a dozen other analysts from various departments. Stan stood at the front, looking like he'd had even less sleep than usual, which suggested the news was very bad.

"Marcus Ashford is dead," Stan said without preamble.

Silence. Then:

"How?" Scott asked.

"Heart attack. Two days ago. He was at a resort in Switzerland, had breakfast, went for a walk, and collapsed. Dead before the ambulance arrived. Official cause: cardiac arrest, likely stress-induced."

"You don't believe that," Erema said.

"I don't believe anything until I've seen the autopsy report and even then I'm skeptical. But the Swiss authorities are calling it natural causes, his family isn't demanding an investigation, and his business partners are already dividing up his assets. If it was murder, it was very clean."

"Who would want him dead?" Harry asked. "Other than us, I mean."

"Everyone he ever worked with. The Architect wasn't exactly known for loyalty. He had partners in Russia, China, the Middle East. Any one of them could have decided he was a liability. Or maybe he really did just have a heart attack. Rich old men have those sometimes."

"What happens to his operations?" Scott asked.

"Unknown. We're monitoring his networks, his shell companies, his communications. So far, nothing suspicious. But the Architect was good at compartmentalization. It's possible he had succession plans we don't know about. It's possible someone else has taken over. It's possible the whole operation died with him."

"Or it's possible this was phase two," Erema said quietly. "Remove the Architect, make it look natural, and continue the work with someone we haven't identified yet."

Stan nodded. "That's my concern. Which is why you're all going to spend the next few months doing very boring surveillance work, monitoring very boring financial transactions, and generally being very bored while we figure out if there's actually a threat or if we're being paranoid."

"Sounds thrilling," Harry said.

"It's not meant to be thrilling. It's meant to keep people alive. You have a problem with that?"

"No sir."

"Good. Get to work."

They dispersed. Scott returned to his desk, to his spreadsheets, to the quiet work of preventing catastrophes that would never happen because they'd been stopped before they started.

It wasn't glorious. But it was necessary.

And sometimes, he was learning, that was enough.

CHAPTER TWELVE: ECHOES

The months blurred together. Scott learned to read financial statements the way he'd once read physics equations—looking for patterns, anomalies, the small details that suggested something larger hiding beneath. Erema consulted on three different cases, helping identify Soviet-era weapons systems that had been sold to private buyers. Harry built predictive models for nuclear material trafficking.

It was quiet work. Important work. The kind that saved lives by preventing crises instead of responding to them.

But Scott couldn't shake the feeling that they were missing something.

It came to a head on a Tuesday in September. Scott was reviewing surveillance photos from a warehouse in Kiev—nothing suspicious, just routine monitoring—when he noticed something in the background.

A shipping container. Marked with a logo he recognized.

He pulled up his archived files, found the logo again: it had appeared in the Granny's records. One of the shell companies used to move the gold from Zurich to Saint John.

"Harry," he called across the office. "Come look at this."

Harry rolled his chair over, studied the photo. "That's Ashford's company. Or it was his company. Now it's owned by—" he pulled up records, "—a consortium of investors. Board consists of five members, all from different countries, all with connections to defense contracting or energy speculation."

"So they split up his empire."

"Looks like it. And they're still operating. Not nuclear materials, at least not that we can prove. But weapons. Conventional arms. Selling to whoever has money and needs firepower."

"Is that illegal?"

"Depends on who they're selling to and what licenses they have. Gray area. Which is probably intentional."

Scott stared at the photo. Something about it bothered him. Not the shipping container itself, but the context. Why would a routine surveillance photo from a warehouse in Kiev show a container from a company connected to nuclear terrorism?

Unless it wasn't routine.

He pulled up more surveillance photos. Different locations—Poland, Romania, Turkey. And in each one, in the background or foreground or just visible at the edge of frame, another container with that same logo.

"They're moving something," he said. "I don't know what, but they're moving it through multiple countries. Creating a distribution network."

"For what?"

"That's what we need to find out."

He took his findings to Stan, who looked at them with the expression of someone who'd been hoping to be wrong and was now resigned to being right.

"I'll put together a task force," Stan said. "We'll monitor the shipments, see where they go, what they contain. If it's weapons, we document it. If it's nuclear materials, we stop it. If it's something else—" He shrugged. "We'll figure it out."

"And if it's another operation like Site Seven?"

"Then we stop that too. Same as we stopped the last one. There's no final victory in this work, McLeod. Just an ongoing commitment to making sure the bad guys don't win today. Tomorrow's a different problem."

"Reassuring."

"It's not meant to be reassuring. It's meant to be true."

The surveillance operation took three months. They tracked the containers through six countries, documented purchases and sales, built a case that would stand up in international court if anyone ever decided to prosecute.

What they found wasn't nuclear materials. It was worse.

"Training manuals," Erema said, reading through intercepted documents. "Complete instructions for acquiring, retrofitting, and deploying nuclear weapons. Everything Alexei worked out for Site Seven, codified and packaged for sale. They're selling the methodology."

"To who?" Scott asked.

"To anyone who can pay. Terrorist organizations. Rogue states. Criminal enterprises. They've turned nuclear terrorism into a franchise operation. You buy the manual, follow the instructions, and for an additional fee they'll connect you with suppliers for materials and technical experts."

"Jesus Christ."

"It's brilliant, in a horrifying way. They learned from Site Seven. Learned that the operation itself is too risky, too complicated, too likely to be stopped. But the knowledge? The knowledge can be sold infinite times. They're not in the nuclear terrorism business anymore. They're in the enablement business."

Harry pulled up financial projections. "If they sell to even ten organizations at the price point they're advertising, they'll make back everything Ashford invested in Site Seven. And those ten organizations will attempt their own operations, which means ten different crises we have to prevent."

"We need to shut this down," Scott said.

"We can't," Stan said. He'd been listening from the doorway. "The operation is decentralized. The board members are in different countries. The shell companies have legal protections. The manuals are technically information, which makes them protected speech in most jurisdictions. We can slow them down. We can make it harder. But we can't stop them completely."

"So they win."

"They don't win. They just don't lose. There's a difference. And our job is to make sure that every organization that buys their manual gets stopped before they can use it. It's going to be exhausting. It's going to take years. Maybe decades. But that's the job."

Scott looked at his team. At Erema, who'd spent decades working for terrible people and was now trying to stop them. At Harry, who'd nearly died in a collapsing nuclear facility and came back to do it again. At the other analysts in the office, all of them working quiet jobs that prevented noisy catastrophes.

"Then we'd better get to work," he said.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN: EPILOGUE

Three Years Later

Scott stood in the parking lot of a decommissioned facility in Nevada, watching demolition crews prep the structure for implosion. It wasn't Site Seven—that was still buried under Manitoba permafrost, officially listed as a geological survey site with restricted access. But it was similar. A relic of Cold War paranoia, now being erased from the landscape.

"Makes you think," Harry said, joining him. He'd flown in from Ottawa for the demolition—partly for work, partly to see an old friend.

"About what?"

"About how much effort we put into building things that could end the world. And how little effort we put into preventing people from using them."

"We're putting in effort now."

"Yeah. Finally."

The demolition team gave a warning. Everyone backed away. The charges went off in sequence—precise, controlled, nothing like Site Seven's chaotic collapse. The building folded in on itself, neat as origami, and when the dust cleared, there was just empty space where threat used to be.

"One more down," Scott said.

"Thousands to go."

"You're optimistic today."

"I've been talking to my therapist. She says acknowledging the scale of the problem is the first step toward dealing with it."

"Is there a second step?"

"Yeah. Keep working. Keep trying. Don't give up just because the problem is bigger than you are."

Erema joined them, carrying coffee in cheap paper cups. She'd stayed in Ottawa, turned her consultant position into a permanent role, become one of CSIS's leading experts on nuclear proliferation. She looked tired but content—the kind of tired that comes from work that matters.

"Stan says there's a new case," she said. "Suspicious uranium purchases in Nigeria. Probably nothing, but it needs to be checked out."

"I'll take it," Scott said.

"You sure? You've been working the Kazakhstan case for six months. You could use a break."

"I'll rest when we've stopped all of them."

"That's never going to happen."

"Then I guess I'll never rest."

She smiled. Not the cynical smile from Paris, but something warmer. More genuine. "You really are an idealist."

"Is that still annoying?"

"Incredibly. But I've gotten used to it."

They watched the demolition crews begin cleanup. Trucks rolling in, equipment loading rubble, the methodical work of erasing what used to be. In a year, this would be empty land. In ten years, maybe a park or a shopping center. In a hundred years, nobody would remember that once, briefly, humanity had been stupid enough to build weapons that could destroy itself.

But Scott would remember. And Harry would remember. And Erema would remember. And all the other quiet people doing quiet work would remember. And that memory would keep them vigilant.

Because that was the job. Not preventing every catastrophe—that was impossible. But preventing enough of them that humanity got to keep existing, keep learning, keep trying to be better than it was.

"We stopped them once," Harry said quietly. "Site Seven. The Architect. We actually stopped them."

"We got lucky," Scott said.

"Maybe. But we also worked hard. Took risks. Made choices that could have killed us but didn't. That counts for something."

"It counts for everything," Erema said. "We're alive. The world's still here. And tomorrow we'll do it again. That's as close to victory as we're going to get."

They stood together, drinking terrible coffee, watching the desert sun paint the mountains gold. Somewhere out there, someone was planning something terrible. Somewhere else, someone was trying to stop them. The work continued. The quiet war against annihilation, fought by people whose names would never be remembered but whose actions might save millions.

It wasn't a happy ending. But it was a hopeful one.

And sometimes, Scott had learned, hope was enough.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

This novel is based on planning notes for a Cold War-era thriller that explores nuclear proliferation, false flag operations, and the quiet heroism of intelligence work. While the characters and specific plot details are fictional, the underlying concerns—aging nuclear facilities, loose nuclear materials, and the potential for nuclear terrorism—are very real.

The world is not made safe by heroes who save it once. It's made safe by thousands of people doing unglamorous work every day to prevent crises that the public never knows about. This book is dedicated to them.

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